

Trust series, 2026 edition: certification memo

What the edition prints. The trust row carries the 2018 figure, 33.8 percent (sampling error 1.68, 1,556 respondents), labelled as the latest figure. No 2024 figure is published and no decade change is published. The 2022 figure the 2024 edition printed, 26.2 percent, is withdrawn. Neither draft is certified: Research's 2024 figure of 24.8 percent and the editor's carried 2022 figure of 26.2 percent are the same kind of figure, each computed from the respondents who were asked the standard question in a survey year in which the web sample was asked experimental versions of it instead.

Why 2024, 2022 and 2021 have no figure

From the 2021 survey onward NORC fielded the trust question to its web respondents in two experimental versions, TRUSTV (the volunteered answer "depends" offered on screen) and TRUSTNV (not offered), and kept the standard question for in person and phone interviews. In 2024 the standard question reached 946 of 3,309 respondents (in person 755, phone 156, multimode 35); all 1,762 web respondents received a version. Rule 3 of the standard requires a figure from every respondent the question was fielded to, on the standard instrument. The 946 are selected by interview mode, so the figure is not an estimate for the population: the versions show how much the instrument matters, 15.7 percent trusting when "depends" is offered (39.6 percent choosing it) against 35.4 percent when it is not, and 25.4 percent if all three are pooled. None of those is the standard instrument on the full sample either.

The 2022 survey has the same structure: the standard question reached 1,198 of 3,544 respondents (in person 1,036, phone 132, multimode 30), and all 1,633 web respondents received the versions. The 2024 edition printed 26.2 percent for 2022 from those 1,198; the figure reproduces exactly under that edition's method and is withdrawn under rule 7, because it does not meet rule 3. In 2021 the standard question was not fielded at all; the 2024 edition's "not fielded" stands. The last survey year in which the standard question reached the full sample is 2018, so 33.8 percent is the figure the edition carries. The decade change is not published because there is no 2024 figure; for the record, 2018 stood +4.2 points above the 2014 base, within its sampling error of 2.26.

The drafts

Research's draft measured the standard question in 2024 on the 946 in person, phone and multimode respondents, correctly weighted and with a design based error, and put the decade change at -4.8 points, not significant. The figure is right for what it counts and not a figure for the series: it leaves out the 1,762 web respondents by mode. Not certified.

The editor's draft carried the 2022 figure of 26.2 percent forward unchanged and published no 2024 figure and no change, which is the right shape of decision applied to the wrong year: the 2022 figure rests on 1,198 non web respondents in the same way. Not certified.

Continuity, the series and the next edition

All 30 rows the 2024 edition printed reproduce from the current file under that edition's method, to the printed precision and respondent count. One is withdrawn (2022); the rest stand. The 1987 figure stays at 43.1 percent on WTSSPS alone, which already carries the Black oversample adjustment (45.2 percent if OVERSAMP were applied on top).

The series' high is 1984 at 49.2 percent and its low is 2014 at 29.6 percent. The largest change between consecutive fieldings is 1983 to 1984, +14.4 points, 5.4 times its sampling error of 2.66, significant.

For the next edition to print a 2026 figure, the 2026 survey has to field the standard trust question, with the same wording and the same offered response options as before, to every respondent in every interview mode, with no experimental versions in its place for any part of the sample. If the versions continue, the series stays at 2018 until NORC publishes a bridged series, and the chapter would say so.

Year	Respondents	Figure	SE	Status
1972	1597	46.6		published

Year	Respondents	Figure	SE	Status
1973	1499	47.2		published
1975	1478	40.0	1.84	published
1976	1495	43.0	1.66	published
1978	1528	38.4	1.98	published
1980	1461	42.7	2.07	published
1983	800	34.9	2.02	published
1984	1461	49.2	1.72	published
1986	1466	37.4	1.79	published
1987	1808	43.1	1.72	published
1988	990	39.5	1.98	published
1989	1030	40.1	1.71	published
1990	898	37.6	2.27	published
1991	1013	38.1	1.79	published
1993	1052	33.6	1.78	published
1994	1995	33.5	1.46	published
1996	1915	32.9	1.21	published
1998	2346	36.7	1.21	published
2000	1879	35.1	1.41	published
2002	910	33.8	2.15	published
2004	875	33.9	1.69	published
2006	2509	32.5	1.27	published
2008	1365	32.2	1.63	published
2010	1372	32.1	1.81	published
2012	1331	31.8	1.91	published
2014	1683	29.6	1.52	published
2016	1946	31.9	1.50	published
2018	1556	33.8	1.68	published
2021	0			no figure
2022	1198	26.2	2.48	withdrawn
2024	946	24.8	2.08	not published